OPPORTUNITY SCANNER FIELD GUIDE

The 2026 Public-Sector Revenue Opportunity Playbook

A source-backed guide to agencies, funded buyers, recipients, primes, partners, and practical next actions.

$179B FY2025 prime federal contracts reported to small businesses	**~$273B** FY2025 prime plus subcontract awards reported to small businesses	**7 steps** From company context to an owned next action

Built for founders and revenue teams that need credible targets, clear revenue motions, contact paths, and next actions - not a generic list of grants or contracts.

Opportunity Scanner by Opportunity Systems

Research current as of July 10, 2026. Always recheck time-sensitive official sources before acting.

Offer and audience

This guide is for founders, revenue leaders, partnerships teams, agencies, and commercial companies deciding whether public-sector money creates a realistic growth path for what they already sell.

Conversion promise: Learn a repeatable method for turning official public records into qualified targets, revenue motions, contact paths, and next actions. The guide does not promise eligibility, awards, contracts, customers, or revenue.

Executive brief

Public-sector opportunity research is often reduced to searching for an open contract or grant. That misses much of the useful market evidence. Official records can show an agency preparing to buy, a prior contractor delivering adjacent work, a nonprofit or institution that received funding, a program likely to create future recipients, or a policy change that may alter demand.

The market is meaningful, but broad totals are not a company's addressable opportunity. The Small Business Administration reported that in fiscal year 2025 nearly 28 percent of prime federal contract dollars, about $179 billion, went to small businesses. Including prime contracts and subcontracts, SBA reported nearly $273 billion awarded to small businesses. Those figures describe federal contracting performance, not all government spending and not the opportunity available to any one company.

The practical advantage comes from narrowing the evidence. A good opportunity row preserves the source, identifies the most plausible target, chooses the right revenue motion, recommends a credible contact path, and assigns a next action that reduces uncertainty.

State of the channel

Trend 1: Small businesses remain material participants in federal contracting

SBA's FY2025 scorecard release reported nearly $179 billion in prime federal contracts to small businesses and nearly $273 billion when prime and subcontract awards are combined.

Business implication: A small or midsize company should not reject the channel solely because it assumes every award goes to a large incumbent.

Recommended action: Identify the agencies and prime contractors already buying adjacent products or services, then qualify direct and subcontracting paths separately.

Trend 2: The useful record appears before and after the open bid

SAM.gov contains pre-solicitation, solicitation, award, and sole-source notices. Acquisition.gov links to recurring agency procurement forecasts. USAspending shows recipients and award history. Grants.gov distinguishes forecasted, posted, closed, and archived opportunities.

Business implication: A solicitation is only one stage of market evidence. Historical awards, forecasts, recipients, and pre-solicitation notices support different decisions.

Recommended action: Label every record by status before assigning a sales action. Never call an award notice an open bid or a forecast guaranteed funding.

Trend 3: Indirect routes often create the more realistic first move

SBA distinguishes prime contractors that work directly with government from subcontractors that work for other contractors. Grants and assistance awards can also create funded recipients that later buy products, services, implementation support, or partnerships.

Business implication: The best first motion may be Sell to Funded Buyer, Sell to Award Recipient, Partner with Recipient, or Channel / Distributor Motion rather than Direct Apply or a direct agency bid.

Recommended action: Compare direct and indirect routes for the same signal, then choose the one that fits the company's readiness and offer.

Trend 4: Source volume increases the need for qualification

Official systems answer different questions and use different definitions. Award, obligation, outlay, recipient, notice, program, and forecast should not be combined as if they measure the same thing.

Business implication: More records can create more noise unless source type, time status, relevance, and next action are normalized.

Recommended action: Require every surfaced signal to pass the qualification test below before it enters a CRM or workflow.

The seven-step opportunity method

Step 1: Translate the company, not just its keywords

Start with the company's products, services, customers, outcomes, delivery model, geography, and constraints. Translate commercial language into public-sector mission problems, procurement categories, program terminology, and likely buyer types. A music network might map to creative workforce, city events, arts education, tourism, and parks programming. A DME supplier might map to VA procurement, rehabilitation, prosthetics, funded providers, reimbursement, and channel partners.

Output: a short company profile plus five to ten source-search concepts.

Step 2: Search by source purpose

Use SAM.gov for federal procurement notices and stage. Use USAspending for federal award and recipient evidence. Use Grants.gov for federal assistance opportunities and status. Use Federal Register for rules, notices, and policy demand. Use agency forecasts and official state or local portals for earlier demand and non-federal activity.

Output: records grouped by source and what each source can prove.

Step 3: Separate live opportunity from market evidence

Assign one status: active opportunity, historical market evidence, policy signal, source route, or research only. Verify dates, notice type, amendments, eligibility, and whether the record is still current.

Output: a defensible source-status label and time-sensitivity level.

Step 4: Name the target

Identify who controls money, purchasing, implementation, or access. The target may be an agency, procurement office, program office, funded buyer, award recipient, prime vendor, distributor, grantee, channel partner, or policy owner.

Output: one primary target organization and buyer/partner type.

Step 5: Choose the revenue motion

Use the motion that matches the evidence: Direct Apply, Sell to Agency, Sell to Funded Buyer, Sell to Award Recipient, Partner with Recipient, Channel / Distributor Motion, Monitor Policy, or Research Only.

Output: one primary motion plus a short reason alternatives were rejected.

Step 6: Build the contact path

Start with source-native contacts, procurement offices, program offices, vendor registration, recipient leadership, prime contractors, or official portals. Personal email enrichment is optional and should not replace a better official route.

Output: a contact strategy, recommended roles, and a manual research instruction when a named person is not yet supported.

Step 7: Assign the next best action

The action should reduce the largest uncertainty. Examples include validating an amendment, checking eligibility, registering in a vendor portal, researching the incumbent prime, confirming a recipient's program scope, or assigning a CRM task with the source attached.

Output: one owned task with evidence, due date, and follow-up state.

Qualification scorecard

Score each dimension High, Medium, or Low rather than inventing false precision:

Dimension	Question	Reject or downgrade when
Offer fit	Does the record map to what the company actually sells?	The connection depends on generic words rather than a use case.
Source confidence	Is the source official and does it support the claim?	The record is secondary, incomplete, or misread.
Timing	Is it active, forecasted, recent, historical, or expired?	Timing is unknown or the deadline has passed.
Target clarity	Can the agency, recipient, prime, or partner be named?	No plausible organization controls the next step.
Motion clarity	Is there a realistic way to sell, apply, partner, or monitor?	The motion assumes eligibility or access without evidence.
Contact path	Is there a credible office, portal, role, or research route?	Outreach would be random or inappropriate.
Next action	Can one task reduce uncertainty now?	The only action is vague additional research.

High Actionability requires strong fit, credible evidence, a named target, and a concrete next action. Medium Actionability needs validation. Low Actionability remains market context or is screened out.

Worked illustrative example

Company context: A workforce-training platform serves employers and training providers.

Source signal: An official Department of Labor award record shows a regional workforce intermediary received funding for sector-based training.

Qualification: The award is historical money-flow evidence, not an open application. The program purpose fits the platform's employer and provider workflow.

Target: The funded intermediary and participating training providers.

Revenue motion: Sell to Funded Buyer or Partner with Recipient.

Contact path: Program director, employer partnerships lead, procurement route, or implementation partner listed by the recipient.

Next action: Confirm the active project period and implementation model, then prepare a source-backed partnership note. This example is illustrative and is not a customer result or claim that the recipient is currently buying.

30-day operating plan

Week 1: Profile the company, define search concepts, and run the first source scan.

Week 2: Review the top 10 to 20 signals, reject weak fits, and assign target, motion, and contact path.

Week 3: Move the strongest five rows into workflow with source links, owners, and next actions.

Week 4: Record outcomes: validated, contacted, monitoring, rejected, or waiting. Use those results to refine queries and qualification rules.

Limits and responsible use

- Public records can lag, change, or omit context. Recheck the official source before acting.
- An award or recipient is not proof of current buying intent.
- A forecast is not a solicitation or guarantee that an acquisition will occur.
- A grant program is not necessarily open, and a company may not be eligible.

- Federal totals do not represent state and local spending or a company's addressable market.
- Contact information in a source may be intended for program or procurement questions, not sales outreach.
- Opportunity Scanner supports research and workflow decisions; it does not provide legal, accounting, grant-writing, procurement, or eligibility advice.

Next-action checklist

- Define the company's public-sector use cases.
- Select official sources by the question they answer.
- Verify status and dates.
- Name the target organization.
- Select one revenue motion.
- Choose an official or role-based contact path.
- Assign one next action.
- Preserve the source in the workflow.
- Record rejection reasons as well as pursued rows.
- Recheck live records before outreach, application, or bid activity.

Evidence and source ledger

Claim or use	Official source	Retrieval date	Caveat
FY2025 small-business federal contracting figures	SBA, official source	2026-07-10	Federal contracting only; not all government spending or company opportunity size.
Annual scorecard purpose and 23 percent aggregate goal	SBA, official source	2026-07-10	Agency goals and results differ.
Prime and subcontractor distinction	SBA, official source	2026-07-10	Participation path, not proof of available work.
Procurement notice types	SAM.gov, official source	2026-07-10	Notice type and status must be checked.
Recipient definition and award research	USAspending, official source	2026-07-10	Recipient does not automatically mean buyer.
Grant opportunity statuses	Grants.gov, official source	2026-07-10	A forecast is not guaranteed to become an announcement.
Agency procurement forecast directory	Acquisition.gov, official source	2026-07-10	Planning signal, not a solicitation or award.

Put this guide to work

Opportunity Scanner reads your company website, finds source-backed public-sector signals, and translates them into target organizations, revenue motions, contact paths, and next actions.

Run a free company scan at opportunityscanner.ai

Recheck official sources before any outreach, application, registration, or bid decision.